

Customer & MVP Blueprint

CertiVerify AI — AI-Powered Academic & Professional Certificate Verification Platform

Derived from the Startup Validation Report (20 July 2026) · Prepared for Founder Use, Investor Conversations & Accelerator Applications

1. Executive Summary

CertiVerify AI uses OCR, machine learning and cross-verification to detect fake, forged or tampered academic and professional certificates for universities, HR/recruitment teams, staffing agencies and EdTech platforms. Certificate fraud is a well-documented, budgeted pain point in India: India's Primary Source Verification (PSV) market is valued at ≈US\$422M (2024), growing to ≈US\$1.48B by 2032 (15.8% CAGR). Government rails (DigiLocker/NAD) cover only institutions that opt in, leaving a large gap of legacy graduates, non-participating boards and physically submitted documents — exactly where CertiVerify AI's AI-forensics wedge fits.

Status: Prototype-stage with informal faculty/student feedback only — no paid pilot, no signed LOI, and no tested pricing yet. Founder-market fit scores 6.3/10 (strong technical fit, weak industry network). The market-level problem is well evidenced by third-party data; buyer-level proof (a registrar, TA lead or HR head confirming willingness to pay) is the missing piece.

2. Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

Attribute	Profile
Org type	Mid-size private universities/colleges; recruitment & staffing agencies; mid-market corporate HR/TA teams (500–10,000 employees); online certificate-issuing platforms
Geography	Tier-1/Tier-2 India first (Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Delhi-NCR, Telangana) → global Phase 2
Volume trigger	200+ certificate/document verifications per month (admissions cycles, bulk hiring, continuous recruitment)
Current process	Manual PDF/photo review by admin staff, or ad-hoc emails to issuing institutions
Budget holder	Registrar/Admissions Head (education); TA Manager/HR Head (recruitment/corporate); Compliance/Ops Lead (agencies)
Buying trigger	A fraud incident, an audit/DPDP compliance requirement, or a scaling hiring/admissions cycle straining manual capacity

3. Buyer Personas

	Persona 1 — "Priya", Head of Admissions	Persona 2 — "Rohit", TA Manager
Role	38, Registrar / Admissions Head, mid-size private university	31, TA Manager, mid-market recruitment agency (300+ placements/mo)
Goals	Process admissions fast without letting forged documents through; maintain NAAC/UGC compliance	Close placements fast without exposing clients to fraudulent-hire liability
Frustrations	Peak-season backlog of manual checks; limited staff; forged marksheets found post-enrolment	Existing BGV vendors slow/expensive at volume; false positives create candidate friction
Decision criteria	Accuracy, turnaround, integration with admissions software, DPDP compliance	Speed (same-day), per-check pricing, API integration with ATS
Channel	Peer referrals, education conferences, LinkedIn outreach	HRTech marketplaces, staffing WhatsApp/LinkedIn groups, direct outbound

4. Top 10 Customer Pain Points

#	Pain Point	Who Feels It Most	Severity
1	Manual verification is slow (days–weeks), delaying admissions/hiring	Registrars, TA teams	High
2	Sophisticated forgeries (altered seals, grades) are hard to catch visually	Registrars, HR, agencies	High
3	No verification path for graduates from institutions outside NAD/DigiLocker	Employers, agencies	High
4	Enterprise BGV vendors are cost-prohibitive at SME/mid-market volumes	SME employers, small colleges	Medium
5	DPDP Act 2023 compliance exposure for mishandled applicant data	Compliance/HR leads	Medium
6	Reputational risk from a single publicised fraud incident	Institution leadership	Medium
7	Peak-season staffing capacity can't absorb spikes in verification volume	Registrars, TA teams	Medium
8	False positives from rigid rule-based checks create candidate/applicant friction	HR, agencies	Medium
9	No consolidated fraud-risk reporting/dashboard for leadership	Institution & agency leadership	Low-Med
10	Cross-border / international certificate verification is largely manual	Corporate HR, global employers	Low-Med

5. Customer Journey

Stage	Customer Activity	CertiVerify AI Touchpoint
Awareness	Experiences a fraud incident, compliance deadline, or manual bottleneck	LinkedIn/content on certificate-fraud trends; referrals; sector visibility
Consideration	Compares manual process vs. BGV vendors vs. new AI tools	Case studies, live demo, transparent accuracy/turnaround benchmarks
Trial / Pilot	Runs a limited pilot on real/historical documents	Free/low-cost pilot tier, dedicated onboarding, fast feedback loop
Purchase	Signs annual/subscription contract, integrates via API/portal	Simple pricing tiers, API docs, dedicated account contact
Retention & Expansion	Monitors fraud-catch rate and time saved; expands to more branches	Usage dashboards, quarterly fraud-trend reports, upsell
Advocacy	Refers peer institutions/agencies; gives testimonial	Referral incentives, co-marketing case studies, conference slots

6. Key Objections & Buying Triggers

Objection	Response Strategy
"We already use DigiLocker/NAD — why this?"	Position as a complementary layer for certificates NAD doesn't cover (legacy years, non-participating boards, physical submissions)
"What if the AI wrongly flags a genuine certificate?"	Human-in-the-loop workflow: AI flags a risk score, ambiguous cases route to manual review, published accuracy benchmarks
"Is applicant data secure and DPDP-compliant?"	Clear data-handling/retention policy; ISO 27001 roadmap; on-shore hosting
"No budget for a new tool this year"	Free/low-cost pilot tied to a fixed number of checks, converting to paid after demonstrated fraud catches or time saved

Buying triggers: a recent fraud incident; an upcoming NAAC/UGC audit or DPDP compliance review; a scaling hiring/admissions cycle that overwhelms manual capacity; a mandate from a parent group, franchise network, or enterprise client requiring verified hires.

7. MVP Recommendation

Build First	Do NOT Build (Yet)	Success Metrics
• Single-document upload → OCR extraction → tamper/forgery risk score • Human-in-the-loop review queue for ambiguous/high-risk cases • Simple web portal for registrars/TA teams (no ATS integration needed yet) • Basic PDF/report export of verification results	• Full API/ATS integrations • Multi-country/international certificate support • Blockchain credentialing or NAD partnership integration • Usage dashboards & quarterly analytics • Mobile app	• 8–10 completed problem interviews • 3+ signed pilot commitments • Precision/recall benchmarks published from pilot data • At least 1 verbal/written willingness-to-pay signal at a stated price

8. MoSCoW Prioritization

Must Have	Should Have	Could Have	Won't Have (v1)
OCR document ingest; tamper-detection model (fonts/seals/pixels); risk-score output; manual review queue; basic result export	DPDP-compliant data handling policy; simple pilot pricing calculator; email/portal notifications	Batch upload for bulk verification; simple analytics dashboard; ATS/LMS plug-in	Full API marketplace; blockchain credential issuance; international board coverage; NAD/government partnership integration

9. Pricing Hypothesis

Segment	Model	Illustrative Price Point
Colleges/Universities	Per-check or annual subscription (volume-tiered)	≈ ■1–1.5L/year (pilot cohort)
Recruitment Agencies	Per-check, scales with placement volume	≈ ■150–300/check or ■2–2.5L/year
Mid-market Corporate HR	Annual subscription with check bundles	≈ ■2.5–3L/year
EdTech/Certificate Issuers	API usage-based pricing	≈ ■3.5–4L/year

Note: pricing is a working hypothesis from the bottom-up SOM model — must be re-calibrated against real budget conversations during the 30-day pilot sprint.

10. Top 5 Risks

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
NAD/DigiLocker/APAAR expands coverage, shrinking the addressable gap	Medium	High	Position as complementary layer; pursue integration/partnership, not substitution
Model accuracy: false positives/negatives erode trust	Medium	High	Human-in-the-loop review; publish and track precision/recall from pilot data
Data privacy/regulatory risk under DPDP Act 2023	Medium	High	Privacy-by-design, data minimisation, consent flows, ISO 27001 roadmap
Long institutional/government sales cycles slow revenue	High	Medium	Prioritise agencies & mid-market HR (faster cycles) alongside education pilots
Solo-founder execution & network bandwidth constraints	High	Medium	Recruit GTM advisor/co-founder; join an accelerator for network access

11. 30-Day MVP Plan

Week	Primary Goal	Key Activities	Success Metric
1	Buyer discovery	Reach out to 20 targets (10 registrars, 10 TA managers); run 8–10 problem interviews; draft pilot-offer one-pager	8–10 completed interviews
2	Pilot recruitment	Convert 3+ contacts into pilot commitments; collect historical certificate batches (genuine + fraudulent); define accuracy benchmarks	3+ signed pilot commitments
3	Pilot execution	Run prototype on pilot batches; log turnaround & flagged cases; mid-pilot check-ins; draft pricing model	Pilot batches processed + benchmark data logged
4	Synthesis & decision	Compile outcomes report (accuracy, time saved, WTP signal); revisit Go/No-Go; decide next step (accelerator, angels, co-founder, or extend)	Outcomes report + updated Go/No-Go

12. Founder Action Sheet — Top 10 Next Actions

#	Action
1	List 20 named target contacts (10 registrars, 10 TA managers/agency owners) from personal/faculty network + LinkedIn
2	Book and run 8–10 structured problem-interview calls this month
3	Draft a one-page pilot offer (scope, free/low-cost terms, success metrics)
4	Collect an anonymised batch of genuine + known-fraudulent certificates to stress-test the model
5	Define precision/recall/false-positive benchmarks to report back to pilots
6	Convert at least 3 interview contacts into signed pilot commitments
7	Draft a simple pricing model (per-check vs. subscription) validated against real budget conversations
8	Write a DPDP-aligned data-handling and retention policy before handling any real applicant data
9	Identify 1 GTM-focused advisor or co-founder candidate with EdTech/HR-tech network access
10	Apply to 1–2 relevant accelerators/incubators to expand network and credibility

13. Scores (0–100)

Dimension	Score	Basis
Customer Clarity	72	ICP, personas and pain points are well-defined; buyer-level validation not yet done
Problem Severity	85	Confirmed via third-party PSV/BGV market data and DPDP/NAAC compliance pressure
PMF Potential	58	Real wedge vs. incumbents, but moderate-high competitive intensity and no paying customer yet
MVP Readiness	55	Prototype exists; pilot batch, benchmarks and pricing model still to be built/tested

14. Final Verdict

■ PROMISING BUT UNVALIDATED

The problem is real, large and well evidenced by third-party market data (India PSV market ≈US\$422M→US\$1.48B), and the technical wedge against NAD/DigiLocker and BGV incumbents is credible. However, there is no signed pilot, no tested pricing, and no confirmed willingness-to-pay yet — moving this from ■ to ■ depends entirely on executing the 30-day buyer-discovery and pilot plan above.